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AI & HEALTH: Doctor vs Internet

DR ANSHUMAN KAUSHAL
Robotic Gastrointestinal Surgeon & Educator

AI has already entered healthcare. It is assisting in diagnostics, managing patient flow, doing insurance approvals and guiding us on where to operate

Eventually we will have digital twins where we can simulate the treatments and the medicine on those digital twins before we actually treat a person

ROBOTIC AIDES IN THE OPERATION THEATRE

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **AI will help doctors but not replace them, as the human touch is essential for breaking bad news or calming a patient**
- **Metabolic drugs don't replace a healthy diet and lifestyle. Misinformation can attract people who don't need these medicines and repel those who do**

Robots and AI are reshaping medical diagnoses, surgeries, insurance and patient flow, "but if you think that a robot is going to replace me, then you are mistaken," Dr Anshuman Kaushal, gastrointestinal surgeon and savvy adopter of such technologies, told the audience at the India Today conclave. Invoking writer Aldous Huxley's 'transhumanist' vision of the future, articulated in his 1932 science-fiction novel *Brave New World*, Dr Kaushal spoke about how technology can complement the skills of medical professionals and surpass their limitations.

As a bariatric surgeon and medical educator, Kaushal's fight, as he puts it, is against obesity, medical myths and pseudoscience. He cites Ozempic-like drugs which, though meant for diabetics to control appetite and blood sugar by regulating the GLP-1 hormone, are mistakenly viewed as an option for weight loss. This is a class of drugs that has to be approached "in a very responsible manner under strict supervision," he said. "There is lot of hype about it and those who really need it are not coming forward because of fear-mongering and misinformation. Those who don't need it are lining up."

India, being the diabetes capital of the world, needs to have proper policy guidelines. "I encourage my patients to ask as many questions as possible. Patients don't just come to get knowledge or information, they also come for trust, for honesty." It's not about a battle of the doctor versus the Internet. "It's about an informed society empowered by technology and anchored by responsible, honest clinicians," he concluded. ■